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NO SIGN OF PRICE DIP, DOMESTIC PRODUCTION BEING RAMPED UP

Fertiliser subsidy burden set to double on global supply crunch

PSUs float tenders for imports, Govt plans to tap Russia to meet demand

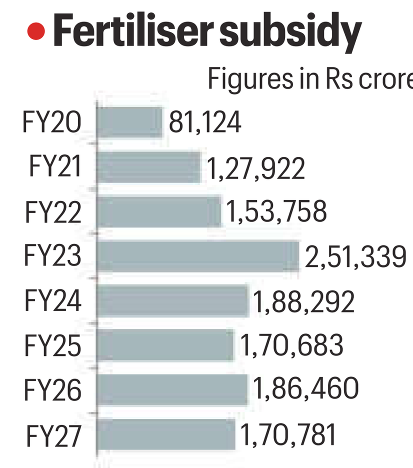
Siddharth Upasani & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, June 9

RISING GLOBAL costs of fertilisers amid a supply crunch is likely to result in a subsidy burden of almost Rs 3.4 lakh crore, or an almost 100 per cent increase compared with the Budget estimate of Rs 1.7 lakh crore, according to top government sources.

"We are still selling fertiliser at a subsidised price of around

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• Fertiliser subsidy



FY26 IS REVISED ESTIMATE, FY27 BUDGET ESTIMATE; SOURCE: BUDGET DOCUMENTS

Congestion at ports, exporters flag carriers' 'opportunistic pricing'

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 9

AMID LOGISTICAL disruption due to the West Asia crisis, Indian exporters are grappling with mounting financial burden posed by "opportunistic" pricing practices by foreign shipping lines and "non-transparent" imposition of detention, demurrage charges

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

The Hormuz fallout

The near closure of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran and the US naval blockade has led to congestion at ports on India's western seaboard and sent freight costs soaring, severely impacting exporters and their margins.

Breakthrough at Zojila

Vehicles pass through the Zojila tunnel after its breakthrough ceremony at Meenamarg in Ladakh, Tuesday. The 13.153-km tunnel, which connects Kashmir Valley to Ladakh, forms the centrepiece of the Zojila project, which is aimed at ensuring year-round access to the region. AP REPORT, PAGE 7

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Fertiliser subsidy bill

Rs 300 per sack even though the cost has gone up from around Rs 2,900 post Covid to around Rs 4,500 now. So, the subsidy (bill) may be 100% more than the Budget estimate," a source, who did not wish to be named, said.

"It's a very complex situation. Global suppliers, including China, are holding on to their stock due to the Iran war. The government is looking at Russia to meet more of its imports," another senior government official told *The Indian Express*.

Another concern that the government is keen to address relates to diversion of fertilisers meant for farmers to the industry. The official said this issue is being discussed at the highest levels of ministries concerned — agriculture, fertilisers and finance.

On May 27, state-owned National Fertilizers Ltd issued a global tender to buy 17 lakh metric tonnes (LMT) of urea. Before that, in early April, Indian Potash Ltd had issued a tender to import 25 LMT of urea.

According to sources, the government does not see signs of fertiliser prices coming down and is trying to ramp up domestic production.

The government had estimated it would need to spend Rs 1.71 lakh crore on fertiliser subsidy in 2026-27. Latest data from the Controller General of Accounts shows the Centre spent Rs 22,033 crore as subsidy in April for urea and nutrient based fertilisers, roughly 13% of the full-year estimate.

For 2025-26, the government raised the revised estimate for fertiliser subsidy to Rs 1.86 lakh crore from Rs 1.68 lakh crore. However, provisional data from the Controller General of Accounts shows the actual amount spent on fertiliser subsidy last fiscal was Rs 2.11 lakh crore – Rs 24,920 crore more than the revised estimate. This is 22% higher than 2024-25.

In addition to the stress on the government finances from the rising fertiliser subsidy, pressure is also coming from elevated fuel prices, with about Rs 1.23 lakh crore lost in the form of revenue foregone due to the Rs 10 per litre excise duty cut announced in March and under-recoveries of public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs), sources said. Prior to the excise duty cut, OMCs were losing about Rs 1,000 crore a day. That figure has now come down to around Rs 650 crore.

While the Centre managed to meet its fiscal deficit target of 4.4 per cent of GDP for 2025-26, the deficit in April surged to a 26-month high of Rs 3.62 lakh crore, accounting for 21.4 per cent of the entire 2026-27 target.

The war in West Asia war and the closure of the key waterway of the Strait of Hormuz has led to a huge jump in fertiliser prices, with India's latest purchases of urea from abroad having been at a cost-plus-freight price of $935-$959 per tonne, more than double the year-ago figure of $410-$420.

Fertiliser was one of the '3 Fs' cited by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman last month – along with fuel and foreign exchange to buy gold – that required a focus amid pressures exerted on the rupee by the ongoing conflict as all these three items had to be paid for in foreign currencies and not rupees on account of them being imported.

Government officials also expressed concern about the diversion of subsidised fertiliser for farmers to industry.

"States have been told that fertiliser to farmers should be provided such that if the requirement, for example, is one sack, they should be given two sacks if needed. But in some states, five and even seven sacks are being given. How can that much fertiliser be even used? Clearly, it is going somewhere else," an official said.

Ports

imposed by port authorities. The country's top export promotion council, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO), has flagged this in a missive to the ministries of Port and Shipping and Commerce and Industry.

The alarm raised by exporters comes after weeks of delays in container evacuation, persistent and heavy congestion across western ports such as Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT), Kandla and Mundra, which together form India's biggest container gateway. Congestion at the port began to swell last month after the heavy influx of stranded West Asia-bound shipments began in the backdrop of the Iran-US ceasefire announced in April.

The FIEO told the government that a Directorate General of Shipping (DGS) advisory issued on March 9, asking stakeholders to "refrain from predatory, non-transparent and opportunistic pricing practices, including levy of exorbitant charges", is not being followed on the ground. "Based on industry feedback, exporters continue to report instances of unilateral and non-transparent levy of charges such as detention, demurrage, War Risk Surcharge, additional freight and related surcharges. In this regard, the possibility of suitable monitoring of audit mechanisms may kindly be examined to assess implementation of the DGS advisory at the ground level and to discourage any non-transparent or opportunistic pricing practices impacting trade," the FIEO wrote on May 19.

In response to a query by *The Indian Express*, a Shipping Ministry representative said Sarbananda Sonowal, Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, has been reviewing the situation and has met various stakeholders, including importers, exporters, the shipping lines and port officials. "He also warned stakeholders not to try extra profit-making by taking advantage of the situation," the representative said. A query mailed to the Commerce and Industry Ministry did not elicit a response.

The Shipping Ministry representative said that in March 2026 and early April 2026, certain containers destined for West Asia had been diverted to Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA) and were given temporary storage at the western port on a transhipment basis. "These containers have later been shipped out to West Asia through the ports of Khor Fakkan, Sohar, and Salalah. Currently, there are no such instances of stranded containers destined to West Asia lying in the port," the representative said.

Exporters said a shortage of transport workers has added to the challenges of the ports and led to a sharp spike in transport costs. An advisory issued by JNPA on May 15 said the recent development of a shortage of trailer drivers due to the vacation season, compounded with elections and other factors, has created a serious impediment in shifting the import containers from terminals to Container Freight Station (CFS).

The Shipping Ministry representative said there has been no strike at JNPA in the past year. "However, there has been a shortage of drivers in April and May, due to drivers taking an annual vacation every year during this period. This year, due to various other issues, including the West Asian crisis, more drivers (above 50%) have gone on leave to their native places. This has caused a certain delay in the evacuation of import containers to CFS. Currently, this issue is also under control," the representative said.

Khalid Khan, former Vice President & Regional Chairman, FIEO, said, "There is a high backlog at ports, and several containers are not able to get in or come out. This resulted in a huge traffic jam at the western ports. And the cost of this traffic jam is borne squarely by the exporters. During a crisis, relief measures should be announced, but even charges for services like lift-on or lift-off charges have gone up several times."

• RESULTS SUGGEST ONCE-DAILY PILL CAN HELP LOWER BLOOD SUGAR & AID WEIGHT LOSS; SIGNIFICANT FOR OVER 100 MILLION INDIANS WITH DIABETES

Easy pill to swallow: New oral GLP-1 drug shows encouraging results during trials

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Pune, June 9

FOR MILLIONS living with Type 2 diabetes and obesity, the future of treatment may not involve needles. Researchers have reported encouraging results from a clinical trial of elecoglipron, an experimental oral GLP-1 drug that not only lowers blood sugar levels significantly but also helps participants lose weight.

The findings are drawing attention because most GLP-1 therapies (which mimic the blood sugar-regulating and hunger-killing gut hormones) currently available are injectable, while the few oral versions come with strict dosing requirements that can make adherence difficult. Presented at the American Diabetes Association's Scientific Sessions and simultaneously published in The Lancet, the results suggest that a convenient once-daily pill could eventually help bridge gaps in diabetes care.

Elecoglipron is a small-molecule GLP-1 drug that can be taken once daily without food or fluid restrictions, potentially making treatment more convenient for patients. Even oral semaglutide, one of the few approved pill formulations, must be taken on an empty stomach with restrictions on food and water intake. The potential significance of oral GLP-1 therapies may be especially important in India, which is home to more than 100 million people with diabetes. Indian patients often develop Type 2 diabetes at lower BMI levels than Western populations because of the so-called "thin-fat" phenotype, characterised by higher visceral fat, lower muscle mass and greater metabolic risk despite a relatively lean appearance.

According to Dr Shashank Joshi, consultant endocrinologist at Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, around one in five Indians with diabetes has a BMI below 23, yet many still have excessive liver fat and significant insulin resistance. This makes treatments that simultaneously improve blood sugar control, reduce body fat and support metabolic health particularly valuable.

• Elecoglipron Advantage

- No food or fluid restrictions, potentially making treatment more convenient for patients
- Potential tool for obesity treatment of adults who are overweight but not diabetic
- Effective for Indian diabetes patients who have lower BMI levels than Western population because of "thin-fat" phenotype
- Side-effects include gastrointestinal issues such as nausea, vomiting, changes in bowel habits
- Larger Phase-3 studies needed before definitive conclusions can be drawn on the drug, say researchers

What the trial found

The Phase 2b SOLSTICE trial, sponsored by AstraZeneca, evaluated the efficacy, safety and tolerability of elecoglipron in adults with Type 2 diabetes. The study enrolled 406 participants across nine countries, including the US. Participants were assigned to different dose groups and followed for 26 weeks.

Researchers found that all tested doses of elecoglipron lowered blood glucose levels significantly more than placebo. Up to 89.6% of participants receiving the drug achieved HbA1c level below 7%, the standard blood sugar target recommended for adults with diabetes. In comparison, only 24.9% of participants receiving placebo reached that goal. Up to 72.3% of participants on treatment achieved at least 5% weight loss compared with 20.2% in the placebo group.

"Our study's findings underscore the expanding potential of oral GLP-1 receptor agonists for people with Type 2 diabetes," said Dr Vanita Aroda, Director, Diabetes Clinical Research in the Division of Endocrinology, Diabetes and Hypertension at Mass General Brigham.

The promise of elecoglipron is not limited to blood sugar control. In a separate study known as VISTA, researchers evaluated the impact of the drug on adults who were obese but did not have diabetes. The trial found dose-dependent and clinically meaningful weight loss over 26 weeks, with benefits continuing through 36 weeks. The findings reinforce growing interest in oral GLP-1 therapies as potential tools for both diabetes management and obesity treatment.

At this stage, the drug's safety profile appears broadly consistent with other GLP-1 medications. Researchers reported that overall tolerability was similar to what has been observed with existing drugs in this class.

Experts caution that larger Phase 3 studies will be needed before definitive conclusions can be drawn. "Phase 3 data are still needed to confirm safety, tolerability and preservation of lean muscle mass before it can be considered a breakthrough therapy," said Dr Joshi.

Shiv Shakti Point soil chemically close to lunar meteorite that hit Antarctica

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, June 9

DATA COLLECTED by India's moon mission Chandrayaan-3 has established a close chemical relationship between the soil found at Shiv Shakti Point, the landing site near the Moon's South Pole, and a lunar meteorite that had hit Antarctica's Allan Hills region of Victoria land about a million years ago.

A new study led by a team of researchers from the Physical Research Laboratory (PRL) noted that the iron and magnesium-rich and aluminum-deficient soil found at the Shiv Shakti point came closest chemically to the lunar meteorite ALHA 81005 discovered in Antarctica in 1982.

Dwijesh Ray, lead author and PRL scientist, told *The Indian Express:* "The Chandrayaan-3 landing site occupies a compositional space between traditional ferroan anorthosite and Mg-suite lithologies (names of different types of rocks), and closely resembles the lunar meteorite ALHA 81005."

Both ferroan anorthosite and Mg-suite lithologies are typical lunar rock types composed of specific elements, like calcium and magnesium.

The lunar surface has suffered numerous micro-meteorite and meteorite hits in the past, as a result of which the regolith layers (the top layers) on its surface have a certain chemical composition. But the possibility of deeper lava and mineral layers mixing with the surface soil as a fallout of these events were not scientifically established yet.

The latest results have emerged from the data gathered by the Alpha Particle X-ray Spectrometer (APXS), a scientific probe onboard the Pragyaan rover on Chandrayaan-3,had landed on the Moon's South Pole in August 2023.

The APXS is designed to unravel the chemical composition of the soil at the Chandrayaan-3 landing site.

The PRL team, in a new publication in the journal Nature, described the soil at the landing site to be a mix composition of a number of chemicals.

E. EXPLAINED

Importance of the findings

The results highlight the compositional diversity that exists within the lunar highlands and demonstrate that different impact histories can expose and redistribute distinct crustal materials across the Moon. For upcoming rover missions, such geochemical information could help prioritise locations that are likely to contain materials excavated from deeper layers, that could prove valuable in providing insights into early evolutionary histories of the Moon.

The Editorial Page

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 10, 2026

Mind investor sensitivities please

OVER THE last few years there has been a flight of capital from India. Foreign portfolio investors took out $14.6 billion from the equity markets in 2024-25, $19.6 billion in 2025-26, and have so far this year withdrawn close to $15.8 billion. Alongside, there has been a sharp decline in net foreign direct investments (FDI). While gross FDI flows have risen from $80.6 billion in 2024-25 to $94.5 billion in 2025-26, net FDI flows stood at just $7.7 billion last year, up from an even lower $1 billion the year before. The collapse in net FDI can be traced to higher repatriation and outward investments by Indian firms. Several explanations have been put forth to explain the trends in FDI flows and investor preferences for other jurisdictions. One explanation revolves around Bilateral Investment Treaties (BITs).

India's BIT 2016 model has been criticised on grounds such as "narrow definitions" and "procedural barriers" like the five-year exhaustion of local remedies before initiating international arbitration (Rethinking India's Bilateral Investment Treaties, RIS Discussion Paper). Prior to the 2016 model, India had signed 83 BITs, of which 74 were ratified. Subsequently, termination notices were sent to 68 countries/regions till March 2023 with requests to renegotiate based on the new framework. However, since then, treaties have been signed with a few countries. The central government is now remodelling its BITs framework -- in the Union budget 2025-26, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman proposed that the current model BIT be "revamped and made more investor-friendly". As per a report in this paper, the key principles on which this centres are a minimum two-year period for local remedies prior to accessing international arbitration, no most-favoured nation clause, and an exclusion of tax-related provisions.

At this critical juncture, the need to attract foreign capital cannot be emphasised enough. Legal certainty must be provided and existing frameworks should be simplified as procedural barriers will only dampen investor enthusiasm. An approach more mindful of investor sensitivities is called for.

My generation understands technology, not privacy

VANSHIKA VERMA

OUR PARENTS taught us not to trust strangers. Not to answer every question they asked. Not to give away our school's name, our address or family details casually. Not to let someone into the house if they could not account for themselves. That wisdom passed through generations, shaped by a simple instinct: Certain information, once given away, cannot be taken back.

I thought about that wisdom recently in a room full of people who would have agreed completely with it and then gone right back to scrolling. A friend of mine had just bought a smart ring. The recommendation came from his gym trainer. It tracked sleep, heart rate, recovery scores, activity levels, and stress indicators through skin temperature. Every morning, he checked his data, adjusted his training accordingly, and discussed the numbers with his trainer. Everyone in the room wanted one. So did I. A device that could optimise your life felt efficient, aspirational, and extremely cool. But when I asked where the data went, the room was silent for some seconds, then went indifferent. One friend wanted to know, "Who is going to look at my sleep data?" Another checked whether the ring came in different colours. My friend assumed the information stayed on the app.

My generation cannot simply be described as ignorant. We are educated, digitally fluent, and fully aware that privacy exists as both a concept and a right. But knowing privacy exists and knowing how to practice it as a dynamic right are two different things. The strangers our parents warned us about are no longer behind the gate. They sit behind a permission screen, a cloud server or an app that promises to make life easier. They do not knock. They simply wait for us to click "agree".

The strangers our parents warned us about are no longer behind the gate. They sit behind a permission screen, a cloud server or an app that promises to make life easier. They do not knock. They simply wait for us to click 'agree'

The data we give away is not trivial. Every OTP, KYC submission, Aadhaar-linked verification and food-delivery profile becomes part of an intimate portrait of who we are. India is not without a legal response: The Supreme Court has recognised privacy as a fundamental right, and the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, and the Rules framed under it, now establish a framework around consent, notice, and user rights. But what is the use of privacy being a fundamental right if we treat it as an irritation?

We need to explore models where children are taught from a young age that data privacy principles must be practised before they learn how to be online. Legislatures, policymakers, institutions, parents, and users share this responsibility.

Privacy has a serious image problem. It is often described as something technical, legal, or distant, when in reality it is deeply personal. Making it feel as important as it truly is will require curriculum, conversation, media literacy, and a greater willingness from companies to be accountable for the systems they build, presenting them in a transparent and understandable manner to the very generations their marketing seeks to attract.

The challenge is not learning how to use technology. It is learning how to live with it, to grow alongside it rather than simply surrender to it, to enjoy its benefits while understanding its costs, and to ask better questions before we click "agree".

The writer is a final-year B.A. LL.B. student at Symbiosis Law School, Noida

MANAV SACHDEVA

There is a barrier to peace — and it is not Iran

MORE THAN 100 days into the conflict in West Asia, the dominant assumption is that Iran remains the main obstacle to regional peace. Yet the events of the recent past suggest a more uncomfortable possibility. The greatest obstacle to an off-ramp may not be Tehran at all, but Benjamin Netanyahu. The conventional narrative portrays him as a leader seeking ever-greater security guarantees before accepting peace. But, his "eternal war" approach may not be the pathway to peace; it may be the mechanism by which peace is indefinitely deferred. A genuine settlement would reopen questions that war postpones. It would bring renewed attention to accountability, coalition instability, and the legal challenges that have shadowed Netanyahu's premiership for years.

This is not unique to Israel. History is filled with leaders who discovered that the end of conflict posed greater risks to their political future than its continuation. But the consequences today extend far beyond Israel's borders. The Palestinian, Lebanese, Iranian, and Gulf Arab populations alike find themselves trapped within a conflict whose continuation threatens lives and livelihoods. The world economy is reeling, and India, too, is not insulated from the economic fallout.

The irony is that the US may actually have a plausible off-ramp. Donald Trump, despite his reputation as a disruptor, is temperamentally well-suited to declaring victory and moving on. The substance matters less than the narrative. A diplomatic arrangement that caps enrichment, reduces tensions in the Gulf, and lowers the risk of direct confrontation could easily be presented as a triumph. Maritime guarantees could be framed as evidence of American strength. Whether such claims would fully reflect reality is beside the point. Political narratives are rarely judged by their precision.

A limited US-Iran accommodation may serve both their interests. But for Netanyahu, it would reduce the centrality of the Iranian threat in his politics, constraining Israel's freedom of military action. It would weaken the claim that permanent emergency is the only viable framework for the region. This is why the concept of the spoiler matters. Spoilers fear the consequences of peace more than those of continued conflict. They do not necessarily oppose negotiations. Instead, they introduce new conditions, expand objectives, question timing, or create new realities that make compromise harder. The spoiler does not need to defeat peace. It merely needs to ensure that peace never quite arrives.

> A limited US-Iran accommodation may serve both their interests. But for Netanyahu, it would reduce the centrality of the Iranian threat in his politics

There was a reason successive US administrations approached direct confrontation with Iran cautiously. Iran is not Iraq or Libya. It sits at the centre of a web of maritime routes, energy corridors and proxy networks that extend far beyond its borders. The Strait of Hormuz remains one of the most consequential chokepoints in the world economy. Escalation rarely remains local. Once the hornet's nest is disturbed, nobody controls the direction of the swarm. Each round of escalation creates pressure for another.

Yet the incentives facing key actors increasingly point in the opposite direction. Political careers and coalitions depend on conflict. In such an environment, peace becomes a threat. The path forward requires more than just diplomacy. It needs the incentives that make perpetual conflict politically useful to be changed. Escalation must become costlier than restraint, and political survival must be separated from permanent crisis. That is a difficult task. It offers no breakthrough and no guarantee of success. And it begins by acknowledging an uncomfortable possibility: The principal obstacle to peace may no longer be the side everyone assumes. Sometimes, the greatest barrier to an off-ramp is not the adversary across the table, but the ally standing beside you. And with friends like these, who needs enemies?

The writer is a diplomat and former UN aid worker

• TELECOM

In HC relief for Airtel and Vi, the lengthy row over spectrum charge

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 9

IN A major financial and regulatory reprieve for telecom operators Bharti Airtel and Vodafone Idea (Vi), the Bombay High Court Monday struck down the Centre's one-time spectrum charge demand estimated at more than Rs 24,000 crore. The court also set aside all consequential actions taken by the government based on the disputed demands. "The respondent (Centre) has not been able to justify the said decisions and its action of levying one-time spectrum charge retrospectively upon the petitioners," the court said in its order. However, the broader legal battle over the charge remains pending before the Supreme Court. Here is what to know.

How airwaves are governed in India

Devices such as phones require signals to connect. These signals are carried on airwaves, which must be sent at designated frequencies to avoid interference.

The Union government owns all publicly available assets within the country, which includes airwaves. These airwaves are called spectrum, which is subdivided into bands of varying frequencies. The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) under the Ministry of Communications regularly auctions these airwaves to private companies.

The current dispute traces its origins to the telecom licensing regime of the 1990s. Under the National Telecom Policy (NTP) of 1994, private operators such as Airtel and Idea Cellular were granted licences to offer mobile services, paying a fixed licence fee as well as separate charges for the use of spectrum. However, the policy was overhauled in 1999 after the government found that the original framework had failed to generate the expected growth in the sector. Under NTP-99, operators were allowed to migrate to a revenue-sharing model under which licence fees and spectrum-related payments were linked to a share of their revenues rather than fixed annual charges.

OVER RS 24,000 CR IN DUES REMOVED

- In 2023, Airtel told stock exchanges that its dues stood at Rs 15,178 crore, of which it had paid Rs 8,500 crore. The remaining Rs 6,600 crore was classified as contingent liability.
- Vodafone Idea, which is facing financial strain, had reported dues of Rs 7,000 crore, including Rs 3,322 crore linked to erstwhile Idea Cellular.
- Analysts estimate the verdict could translate into cumulative relief of more than Rs 24,000 crore for the telcos by removing the liability and associated uncertainty from their books.
- The status quo holds for payments already made. Other issues will be decided in the SC case, brought by Airtel, Vi, etc.

Change in policy

Over the following years, the government and the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) introduced a series of changes governing the allocation of additional spectrum. Operators that received bandwidth beyond the initial allocation had to pay higher revenue-share-based spectrum charges. Industry bodies accepted this framework and withdrew several legal challenges, while successive policy documents and committee reports largely favoured recurring spectrum usage charges rather than upfront one-time levies.

The debate shifted in 2008, when the DoT began exploring the idea of imposing a one-time charge on spectrum holdings beyond 6.2 megahertz (MHz). A panel recommended an upfront payment mechanism for excess spectrum, and in 2010, the TRAI formally recommended a one-time spectrum charge for holdings above the threshold. The move gained momentum after the Supreme Court's 2012 judgment in the 2G spectrum case intensified scrutiny on spectrum allocation and pricing.

In November 2012, the Union Cabinet approved the levy of one-time spectrum charges on existing operators, including retrospective charges on spectrum held beyond 6.2 MHz from July 2008 onwards. The DoT subsequently issued demand notices to operators such as Airtel and Vodafone Idea, prompting them to approach the Bombay High Court in January 2013.

The court granted interim protection against coercive action, and the matter was pending for more than a decade before this week's ruling, which effectively nullifies the Centre's 2012 decision.

• DEMOGRAPHY

Across world, why fewer people are having children

From India to Sweden to Japan, fertility rates are falling irrespective of economic and social conditions. A look at the factors driving this

RISHIKA SINGH

A FINANCIAL INCENTIVE of Rs 30,000 for a couple upon the birth of their third child. More state-funded IVF attempts for first-time parents. A plan to orient around 300,000 units of public housing towards households raising children.

These are just some of the many policies introduced by governments across the world in recent years to encourage childbearing. Last month, Andhra Pradesh became one of the first Indian states to announce payments for having more than two children. Sweden and Japan have also proposed various solutions to the common concern of demographic decline.

In some ways, the transition has been expected. Many societies see smaller population increases over time, owing to improvements in health, education and economic indicators. But the pace and scope of this transition are unexpected.

Rapid TFR decline

Among the most important figures in population growth is the total fertility rate, or TFR. It is the average number of children that a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime. A "replacement rate" of 2.1, that is, an average of two children per woman to replace the mother and father, is considered ideal to ensure population stability.

As of 2023, in over two-thirds of the total global population, TFRs were below 2.1.

From a global average of 5.3 in the early 1960s, TFR stood at 2.2 in 2024 — just above the replacement rate. In this period, the TFR in India declined from 5.9 to 2 — just below the replacement rate. Announcements like Andhra's mark a reversal from a few generations ago, when the population boom was among the biggest crises for the nation and family planning policies were introduced.

Moradhvaj Dhakad, a scientist and Marie Curie Research Fellow at the Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research in Rostock, Germany, told *The Indian Express*: "The decline has happened much faster than UN projections from around a decade ago, which expected TFR to fall to under 2.1 between 2030 and 2035, but India achieved this level around 2020."

Many drivers

According to the demographic transition theory, as societies move from low economic growth and education levels to prosperity, both birth and death rates fall, with little overall change in population as a result. But the widespread shift in just a few decades has prompted the search for other factors.

Income is often a starting point. Martin Kolk, an Associate Professor at the Stockholm University Demography Unit and Department of Sociology, told *The Indian Express* that in the past, people with smaller incomes had more children in many countries. "It now appears that in more and more contexts, people with higher incomes are actually having more children, including rich East Asian societies such as Japan (TFR 1.1) and South Korea (TFR 0.7, among the lowest globally). It's the richest individuals who have more children, but in middle-income countries, you often see the reverse pattern still," he said.

Dhakad also chalked this up to urbanisation, which has raised living costs. Women's increased educational attainments, participation in the workforce and ability to make reproductive decisions also matter. In sub-Saharan Africa, with TFRs as high as 4 and 5, high levels of teen pregnancies have been attributed to limited use of contraception, low education levels and early marriages.

The endurance of traditional gender roles means that women end up shouldering domestic responsibilities in addition to working towards their career aspirations, and many then choose not to have children, or have fewer children. While India has a low share of women in the workforce, strides in health and education could have played a role, Dhakad said.

"Government population control campaigns such as *hum do, hamaare do* further spread family planning messaging even among the less educated groups, and in rural areas. Moreover, it has been found that development is the best contraception... Parents realise that they do not need to have more children to ensure their survival into adulthood," he said.

Still, these factors do not tell the whole story of countries such as Sweden (with a TFR of 1.4), which are rich and have substantial state support for women after childbirth, alongside men making larger contributions to domestic responsibilities.

Kolk said these policies have helped prevent an even steeper decline in TFR: "In the Nordics, fertility has decreased from high to moderate levels and in southern Europe, it has fallen from low to very low levels. In these different contexts, the explanation is likely related to pro-family policy." "But if we want to understand why fertility is falling in basically all countries from 2010 and 2015 to 2025 — both in systems with more and less generous family policy — cultural reasons are probably more important... people prioritise childbearing less," he said.

Australian demographer Peter McDonald has argued that two major trends can be traced back to the second half of the 20th century. The first was a rise in social liberalism, marked by individuals re-examining social norms, choosing what suited them and focusing on individual aspirations. The other was the withdrawal of the welfare state in many Western economies. One byproduct of these trends was that having children was no longer a mandate for living a good life.

Yet another trend is the rise in the number of single individuals and declining rates of marriage. Others have suggested that the rise of technology and smartphones (which have led to fewer in-person interactions) and hardening political divides on gender lines could be preventing people from coupling up. Climate change-related concerns may also be affecting any decision to raise children.

Worry for society

Kolk said that already, the effects of very low TFR in some countries are noticeable: "In South Korea, for every newborn child, there are three-and-a-half 55-year-olds... When the fertility is so low, at 1 or below, then societies will face challenges in maintaining pension systems and paying for public health care for the elderly." This will also likely lead to higher taxes on those in the working population.

With life expectancies increasing, "There will be very many elderly people within families and very few adult children to take care of them," Kolk added.

Immigration has been suggested as a solution to the shortage of workers and caregivers, but also led to a backlash. In India, too, the low TFRs of South Indian states are flashpoints in political debates about delimitation and political representation.

Kolk, however, said that a TFR between 1.5 and 1.7 may not lead to dramatic socio-economic challenges everywhere. "Society will be slightly ageing, but it's something that most rich societies should be able to handle by re-designing the social policy system." The private sector could also improve its policies, he said, noting that expectations of overtime work are prevalent in East Asia, which has very low TFRs.

Can state intervention help?

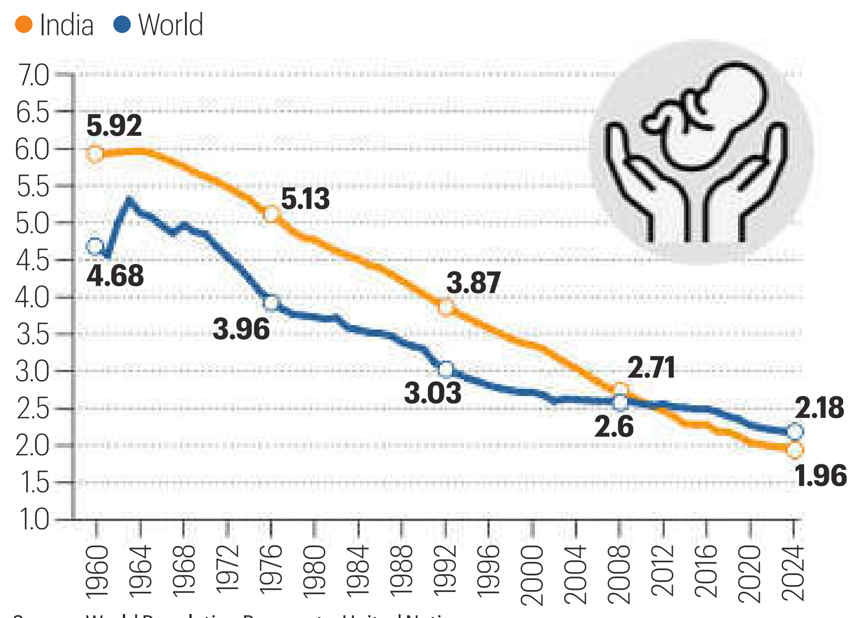
Dhakad said: "In India, population will continue to increase because of the population momentum, thanks to a younger population." But whether this "window of opportunity" is seized will depend on how governments channel existing human capital and meet the youth's aspirations.

Gradually, India, too, will have to prepare for higher public spending on health — something states such as Kerala are already planning for. Kolk said that in societies that have got old before growing as rich, like China, increasing TFRs would have to involve "family-friendly policies that are more like European welfare states". A return to the days of over-2 TFR is unlikely, with several factors influencing the decline, and mitigation could be a strategy.

Dhakad said: "Overall, reducing fertility is easier than increasing fertility," as countries are finding out.

• Fertility rates in freefall

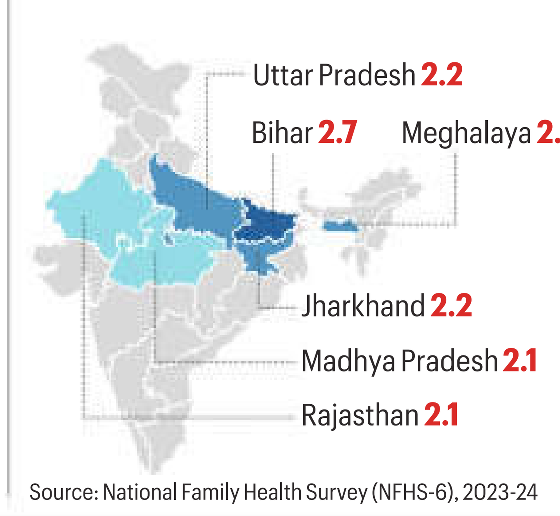
The total fertility rate (TFR), the average number of children that a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime, has declined across the world and in India.



Source: World Population Prospects, United Nations

• In most states, fertility below replacement level

The map shows the only states with TFR at or above 'replacement level' (2.1 children per woman). This is the level needed to maintain a stable population



Source: National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6), 2023-24

Preparing for the transition

By 2050, the proportion of elderly persons in India is expected to increase to 20.8% of population, that is around 34.7 crore.

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This would necessitate the need to invest in healthcare, social support and care infrastructure.

• POLITICS

Can a political party use cockroach as symbol? What EC rules say

Damini Nath
New Delhi, June 9

EVER SINCE Chief Justice of India Surya Kant's "cockroach" remark, the image of the insect has come to be used by those protesting against the statement as well as the satirical Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

CJP is not a political party but a "youth pressure group", according to its founder Abhijeet Dipke. Dipke has not ruled out applying for registration as a political party with the Election Commission (EC) in the future, but for now, the group has an online presence and held its first protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on June 6.

Even if the CJP, or any other group for that matter, were to register as a party and apply for the cockroach as its election symbol, the EC is unlikely to allot it. Here's why.

What do the rules say?

The EC allots election symbols to parties and independent candidates as per the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968. According to the Order, the recognised national and state parties' candidates are allotted the reserved symbol of their respective parties — for instance, the lotus for the BJP, or the raised hand for the Congress. For unrecognised parties, which are registered parties that have not met the electoral performance criteria for the national or state party tag, or independent candidates, the EC allots symbols from a list of "free symbols". These candidates and unrecognised parties can request for their choice of symbol from the list, but they are not assured of getting the same.

What kinds of symbols are allowed?

In the list of free symbols, which the EC revises from time to time, images include fruits, vegetables, household appliances, farm equipment, sports equipment, etc. The latest list, published by the EC in May 2025, has 184 symbols, including AC, balloon, doorbell, dustbin, frying pan, jackfruit and grapes. Some household items such as immersion rod, latch, mixer, toothbrush, and TV remote are also on the list. Also present are a variety of fruits and vegetables as well as other food, including cake and toffees.

The EC list also says that certain symbols can be allotted freely except in certain states and Union Territories. For instance, the apple can be allotted to a party "in all States and Union Territories except in the States of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim, Tripura, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu, Kerala & Karnataka".

This is because in the states mentioned above, the symbol has already been allotted to a recognised state party. This means two different recognised parties in two different states can have the same election symbol: there is no rule against it, and these parties are unlikely to contest against each other.

Can a creature be an election symbol?

Following representations from animal welfare activists in the 1990s, the Election Commission stopped allotting animals as election symbols.

Former Union Minister and founder of People for Animals (PFA) Maneka Gandhi wrote in a post on the PFA website that for the 1989 Tamil Nadu Assembly election, the AIADMK faction led by J Jayalalithaa was allotted the rooster as its symbol. She claimed that thousands of roosters were tied to the top of fast-moving vehicles during the election campaigning, leading to many of these birds dying.

The Bahujan Samaj Party, which was formed prior to the ban, still retains its election symbol, the elephant, making it one of the few exceptions. With the EC's prevailing stand against allotting animals as election symbols, the cockroach symbol is unlikely to be granted if anyone seeks the same, EC officials said.

Picking a poll symbol

- The EC allots symbols from a list of "free symbols" for either registered parties that haven't met electoral performance criteria for the national or state party tag or independent candidates.
- The latest list, published in May 2025, has 184 symbols, including air-conditioner, balloon, door bell, dustbin, frying pan, jackfruit and grapes.

• HEALTH

Monthly, not weekly shots: New obesity drug promises easier weight management

EXPERT EXPLAINS
DR ANOOP MISRA
CHAIRMAN AT FORTIS CDOC HOSPITAL FOR DIABETES AND ALLIED SCIENCES

PHARMACEUTICAL GIANT Pfizer has just declared mid-stage trial results for berobenatide, an experimental anti-obesity and diabetes drug designed to be taken just once a month. If approved, it could become the first GLP-1 weight-loss therapy (which mimics the gut hormone GLP-1 to regulate blood sugar, slow stomach emptying and reduce appetite) to be administered as a once-a-month injection instead of weekly jabs.

The drug is drawing attention not just for weight loss but convenience. Current blockbuster obesity drugs require weekly injections. Pfizer's candidate aims to reduce that burden; patients would initially receive weekly doses before transitioning to a single injection every month. For people managing obesity as a chronic condition, that would ultimately mean 12 injections a year instead of 52. In a mid-stage clinical study, patients without diabetes lost up to 12.3% of their body weight. Importantly, those who switched to monthly dosing continued to lose weight rather than hitting a plateau.

"However, we should not compare the percentage of weight loss. Less frequent dosing has the potential to improve treatment persistence, which is a major determinant of long-term success in obesity management," says Dr **Anoop Misra**, Chairman at Fortis CDOC Hospital for Diabetes and Allied Sciences and former professor, AIIMS, Delhi. He spoke to **Rinku Ghosh** about the new treatment.

Pfizer's berobenatide is being positioned as a once-monthly GLP-1 therapy. How is this significant from a patient adherence and treatment-compliance perspective?

Berobenatide is currently transitioning into a robust global phase 3 development programme, which consists of 10 planned or ongoing late-stage clinical trials. It is expected to be available for patients around late 2028 to mid-2029. The drug has been engineered to remain in blood circulation much longer than conventional GLP-1 therapies, allowing sustained activation of GLP-1 receptors throughout the month. From an Indian perspective, a once-monthly GLP-1 injection is important because long-term adherence remains a major challenge. Less frequent dosing may reduce treatment fatigue, improve convenience and help patients remain on therapy for longer periods.

The drug showed up to 12.3% weight loss. How should clinicians interpret these results in comparison with established therapies such as Wegovy, Zepbound and Mounjaro?

Clinicians should avoid direct comparisons across trials. The reported weight loss is clinically meaningful and encouraging for monthly therapy. However, semaglutide (Wegovy) and especially tirzepatide (Zepbound, Mounjaro) have demonstrated substantial weight reductions in larger and longer studies. At present, berobenatide appears promising, but its major differentiating feature may be monthly administration rather than weight-loss efficacy.

The side-effect profile appears broadly comparable to existing GLP-1 drugs. What will experts be looking for in late-stage trials before judging its clinical value?

Experts will focus on the durability of weight loss, long-term safety, gastrointestinal side effects, discontinuation rates, and cardiovascular and kidney benefits. They will also examine whether the extended drug exposure over an entire month leads to any unique safety concerns. In that way, it may undergo similar scrutiny as once-a-month insulin.

Could less frequent dosing improve long-term outcomes for people living with obesity, or are efficacy and side effects likely to be deciding factors?

Less frequent dosing has the potential to improve treatment persistence, which is a major determinant of long-term success in obesity management. However, efficacy and tolerability will continue to be the most important factors. A monthly injection is attractive, but patients and clinicians will ultimately prioritise how much weight is lost, how well it is maintained, and whether side effects remain manageable. Other long term data (especially cardiac) are clearly needed to address these concerns.

GLP-1 drugs are seen as long-term treatments for a chronic disease. How might a monthly injection change the way obesity is managed in routine clinical practice?

A monthly injection could further strengthen the concept of obesity as a chronic disease requiring long-term treatment, similar to diabetes or hypertension. In India, it may improve patient acceptance, reduce the burden of frequent injections, and facilitate longer-term treatment engagement. This could be particularly useful in busy clinical settings and for patients who find weekly injections inconvenient.

Do you see the future of obesity treatment moving toward longer-acting therapies, combination drugs, or more personalised approaches?

The future is likely to involve all three. Finally, the ease of administration (once monthly) and cost are key determinants. Further, personalised approaches based on liver disease (liver fibrosis), presence of obstructive sleep apnea, knee osteoarthritis, are likely to guide treatment selection. For India, where obesity and diabetes have varied patterns, personalised obesity medicine may become important.

BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

NASA names astronauts for Artemis III docking mission

The NASA logo is seen at Kennedy Space Center in Cape Canaveral. FILE

NASA ON Tuesday named three U.S. astronauts and an Italian astronaut to serve as the crew for its next Artemis mission, a spacecraft docking demonstration in Earth's orbit next year that will test landers from Elon Musk's SpaceX and Jeff Bezos' Blue Origin for the first time in space. NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman at a ceremony in Houston named U.S. astronauts Andre Douglas, Frank Rubio and Randy Bresnik and Italian astronaut Luca Parmitano as the Artemis III crew, which is due to launch late next year. “Artemis III is an incredibly exciting,and highly coordinated multi-launch campaign,” Jeremy Parsons program manager said. REUTERS


Red Cross workers disinfect Rwampara General Hospital amid efforts to contain an Ebola outbreak in eastern Congo. FILE

With few masks, no boots, Congo’s Ebola medics left exposed

Reuters
Nairobi, London, June 9

NEARLY A month into one of the world’s largest ever Ebola outbreaks, medics in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo are struggling to secure basic equipment to stay safe and prevent further spread of the disease, according to more than a dozen doctors, humanitarian workers and public health officials.

While major donors are surging funding, the size of the outbreak, reductions in pre-positioned stocks due to aid cuts, and logistical problems have caused shortages and driven up costs for personal protective equipment.

The International Rescue Committee aid group warned on Tuesday that stocks of essential protective equipment are expected to run out within days.

In North Kivu, one of three affected provinces that have confirmed over 550 cases and 100 deaths, medical teams are close to exhausting items like chlorine and often lack equipment including boots, said Pablo Lwanzo Paluku, chief doctor for the Butembo zone.

A suspected Ebola victim's body was wrapped in a blue tarpaulin and transported on a taxi roof due to the lack of a body bag or ambulance, he said. “What little we have is improvised,” said Paluku.

As of June 4, only a quarter of critical supplies needed for the next three months had arrived in Congo and Uganda, which has reported 19 cases, with face shields and alcoholic gel particularly short, according to the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention.

Already, 34 healthcare workers have been infected with the rare Bundibugyo strain of the virus and seven have died, just over three weeks after the WHO declared an international emergency.

CURBS MOSTLY ON INSTITUTIONAL PLAYERS, RETAIL AUDIENCE INSULATED

MFs place curbs on large gold ETF inflows amid forex pressure

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 9

SEVERAL LARGE mutual fund houses have suspended fresh subscriptions into their gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) and fund of funds (FoFs) as the ongoing conflict in West Asia continues to swell the country's imports bill and put pressure on foreign exchange reserves.

HDFC Mutual Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Tata Mutual Fund and Nippon India Mutual Fund have all placed such curbs on gold ETF schemes, which came into effect between June 5-8.

"Investors are requested to note that the Board of ICICI Prudential Trust Ltd has approved temporary restriction on subscriptions of ICICI Prudential Gold ETF (Gold ETF) with effect from the close of market hours of June 5, 2026. Subscriptions in Gold ETF directly with ICICI Prudential Asset Management Company Ltd (AMC) by eligible investors for an amount exceeding Rs 25 crores shall not be accepted till further notice," said ICICI MF.

Other fund houses also placed similar curbs on fresh subscriptions into their gold ETF schemes.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had last month called upon the public to help the country battle against the threats posed by the West Asia war, announcing measures to curb fuel usage, gold imports and foreign exchange drain.

Under the SEBI regulations, gold ETFs are mandated to invest 95% of their net assets in physical gold and other SEBI-mandated gold instruments, which drives up the need for gold imports.

Notably, these restrictions are applicable only for large transactions in the segment, with other services such as SIPs and redemptions still open for investors. Thus, these are aimed at restricting inflows from institutional investors rather than retail participants.

Gold import bill for the March 2026 quarter was $ 22.57 billion and full year of FY26 at $ 71.97 billion as against $9.5 billion and $ 58 billion respectively in the previous year, RBI data says.

Many industry players welcomed measures announced by the fund houses.

• GOLD IMPORT PROBLEM

HDFC MUTUAL Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Tata Mutual Fund and Nippon India Mutual Fund have all placed such curbs on gold ETF schemes, which came into effect between June 5-8

THE MOVE comes after Prime Minister Modi last month called upon the public to help the country battle against the threats posed by West Asia conflict

THESE RESTRICTIONS are likely to dampen the momentum seen in gold ETF inflows over the past few months

"We hope other AMCs also follow suit, because as an industry, we have to recognise that excessive financialisation of gold at elevated prices can add to import demand, put pressure on the current account deficit, and eventually contribute to rupee depreciation. Our stance on gold has been very clear. Indians should not only stop buying gold at these levels, but also look at selling a small portion of their idle gold holdings," according to Feroze Azeez, joint CEO of Anand Rathi Wealth.

Calling these restrictions on gold ETF inflows a "responsible step," Azeez said, "India holds nearly $4 trillion worth of household gold, while the current account deficit is around $65 billion. That means even 1% to 1.5% of household gold coming back into circulation can make a meaningful difference to India's external finances."

These restrictions are likely to dampen the momentum seen in gold ETF inflows over the past few months.

"It looks likely that such curbs are expected to remain until there is some meaningful resolution in West Asia. Gold and silver ETFs have become a popular avenue to hedge for institutional players, especially during the risks that exist today. That explains some of the reason why flows into gold ETFs have boomed, alongside retail interest. However, if hedging is taken out of the equation, flows might dry up a bit in the coming months," a fund manager at a domestic fund house said.

Notably, investments in gold ETFs crossed that into the traditionally popular equity funds for the first time when it had more than doubled month-on-month to a record high of Rs 24,040 crore in January 2026.

This was on the back of gold's rise to prominence at a time when US tariff threats had drawn safe-haven demand for the precious metal.

However, inflows have since moderated to the pre-boom levels of Rs 2,000-Rs 4,000 crore as the safe-haven demand has since shifted to the dollar.

FCNR(B) DEPOSITS SWAP SCHEME

Why higher interest rates may be needed to bring in NRI dollars

George Mathew & Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 9

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) last week announced, until September 2026, the special dispensation that allows banks to mobilise fresh three- to five-year Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) — FCNR(B) — deposits and permitted them to swap these deposits with the RBI at a concessional rate, effectively covering the entire hedging cost.

By absorbing the hedging burden, the RBI has made FCNR(B) deposits a more attractive source of overseas funding for lenders. Experts believe the steps announced by the RBI may attract an additional $50 billion-$70 billion in foreign capital into Indian markets, provided the banks offer the right interest rates after considering the hedging sops.

But bankers say the regulatory incentive alone may not suffice to trigger large inflows. With US dollar deposit rates in major markets like the US still offering returns of over 4%, Indian banks may need to raise FCNR(B) deposit rates by at least 100 basis points to remain competitive and persuade NRIs to shift funds to India. In FY26, FCNR(B) deposit inflows plunged by 86 per cent to $946 million from $7.1 billion in FY25, with the amount outstanding rising to $33.8 billion at the end of March. Unless banks offer a meaningful rate premium over overseas alternatives, the response from depositors may remain muted despite RBI's support.

What are FCNR (B) deposits?

FCNR(B) deposits are fixed-term bank deposits that can be opened in India by non-resident Indians (NRIs) and Overseas Citizens of India. They allow overseas Indians to maintain their savings in designated foreign currencies such as the US dollar, pound sterling, euro, Japanese yen, Australian dollar and Canadian dollar, rather than converting their funds into Indian rupees. Interest earned on FCNR(B) deposits is exempt from income tax in India as long as the depositor qualifies as a non-resident under Indian tax laws. Under the current framework, banks can offer rates linked to globally accepted benchmark rates.

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FCNR rates now

Compared with conventional rupee fixed deposits, interest rates on FCNR(B) deposits remain significantly lower, typically by 250-300 basis points or more. For instance, SBI currently offers 3.35% on FCNR(B) deposits with a tenure of 3-4 years, 2.95% for 4-5 years, and 3.05% for maturities above five years. HDFC Bank offers 3.65% for 3-4 year FCNR(B) deposits and 3.40% for tenures above four years, while ICICI Bank offers 3% for 3-4 year deposits and 2.90% for deposits exceeding four years.

Compared to this, SBI offers 6.30% for a normal 3-year fixed deposit (FD). HDFC and ICICI offer 6.50%% for 3-5 years tenure.

The lower rates reflect the fact that FCNR(B) deposits are maintained in foreign currencies such as the US dollar, pound sterling, euro and Canadian dollar, regions in which benchmark interest rates are generally lower than domestic rupee rates. However, the RBI's latest relaxation on FCNR(B) deposits is expected to improve the economics of mobilising such funds. By allowing banks to raise fresh three- to five-year FCNR(B) deposits without bearing the full cost of hedging foreign exchange exposure, banks can offer more attractive rates to overseas depositors without significantly impacting their margins.

Why Indian banks should hike rates

Indian banks are yet to work out and announce the new rates on FCNR(B) deposits. "Banks need to more than match the interest rates offered by foreign banks in various jurisdictions like the US. Otherwise, funds won't come. FCNR(B) deposit inflows declined sharply in FY26," said an official of a nationalised bank.

SBI currently offers around 3.85% on three- to five-year US dollar Certificate of Deposit (CD) products in the US. Comparable offerings from US banks are slightly higher, with Merrick Bank providing a 4.20% annual percentage yield on a three-year CD and Morgan Stanley offering about 4.30% APY on a five-year CD. These rates are higher than what are being offered by Indian banks for FCNR(B) scheme.

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